country. Actually, Gogoi had returned from the US on 6 September and stayed at Tata Tea's guest house in Calcutta for five days. An embarrassed chairman later clarified that he was unaware of Gogoi's whereabouts at that point in time. But this episode would come back to haunt the group later.

After these meetings, Tata Tea put out a press release, giving information on what had transpired in them. The company reiterated that it had not funded any militia despite intense pressure and threats. The group also used the release to reveal that the chief secretary of Assam had admitted that 'he had no evidence of Tata Tea's involvement in any payments'.

Ratan's efforts to clear the Tatas' name were relentless. Three days after the meetings, he wrote to the CII President N. Kumar and FICCI President A.S. Kasliwal, countering the allegations made by DGP Hrishikeshan and reiterating the points he had made in his meetings and press releases.

Ratan's efforts helped generate favourable public opinion for the Tatas. On 24 September a daily published an article supporting the group and saying that the tea industry deserved 'public sympathy and not ridicule'. It added that saving the life of the Assamese lady [Pranati Deka] even if the group knew her identity, was a 'humanitarian act', similar to medical treatment given to injured enemy soldiers. It also praised Ratan's 'patience and perseverance' without succumbing to threats, which had led to the release of Bolin Bordoloi. Similar support came from several other newspapers and the West Bengal Working Journalist Association, which, in a letter sent to Ratan on 24 October, went to the extent of terming the stance taken by Chief Minister Mahanta as 'mad'.

There was, however, no let-up on the pressure from the Assam police. After investigations, it had concluded that Tata employees S.S. Dogra and Gogoi knew that Deka was the ULFA cultural secretary and one of her escorts, Phanindra Medhi, was a wanted ULFA activist. On the basis of its findings, on 15 September, Dogra was arrested by the Assam police for 'abetting the efforts of an outlawed organisation waging war against the state' and extending financial aid to ULFA.

Meanwhile, Gogoi had got himself admitted to Woodland Nursing Home in Calcutta. On 18 September, he called the Tata Tea office from the nursing home. This was the first time he had contacted the company since his departure to the US. On 22 September, the Assam police, unable to locate him, wrote to Tata Tea, instructing the company management to 'direct Dr Brojen Gogoi to report to the investigating officer … within the next four